

OMAIB Round 3 Briefing Webinar

Challenge-led Open Multimodal AI Benchmark



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6 October 2026 | 12:00–13:00 BST



First the problem. Then the funded team.

- Now: owners propose a real-world problem and available resources.
- Next: researchers apply to join the challenge-led sandpit.
- R3 funds the benchmark so others can develop and compare solutions.



Multimodal = two or more types/sources of data, beyond text and images.



Why propose a challenge?

- Define an impactful problem that needs a benchmark for your organisation or sector under realistic conditions
- Work with multidisciplinary researchers on reusable evaluation tools and baselines
- Bring a wider research community to the problem to develop and compare more deployable solutions



The challenge we are looking for

- An unmet need with credible users or beneficiaries
- Complementary data and a feasible access route
- An open benchmark for useful comparison
- Owner commitment: time, expertise and resources

Explain practical involvement in the problem, beyond a research interest.



What a concrete challenge could look like

University-linked cancer programme

- Need: prioritise laboratory tests of candidate cancer treatments.
- Data: images + molecular profiles with laboratory treatment responses.
- Test: compare response prediction when inputs are missing or shift.

Materials research facility

- Need: choose which candidate materials to test next.
- Data: processing records, images and measured material properties.
- Test: predict properties across batches and testing conditions.

Illustrative examples, not selected challenges or preferred topics.

In each case, a real owner supplies the data route, domain expertise and intended users.

Challenge owners



- Industry, labs, charities, healthcare and public bodies
- Universities and university-hosted facilities are welcome
- Genuine problem, credible beneficiaries and resources
- Show practical responsibility or involvement

Same published criteria for every owner. No existing UKOMAIN partnership required.



Owner and funded team: separate roles

Challenge owner

- Defines the problem and users; provides data access and expertise.
- Co-designs at the sandpit; gives domain assessment input.
- Supports the project as a **project partner**, not a funded applicant.

Funded research team

- Forms or develops at the sandpit; co-designs the benchmark project.
- Applies through an eligible PI at a different organisation.
- Receives the grant if selected; is accountable for implementation.

For its own challenge, the owner's organisation cannot be lead applicant or co-applicant. UKOMAIN makes funding decisions independently.



How academic groups can engage now

- OWN: propose a genuine problem with data/resources and a commitment to support a separate funded team
- CONNECT: introduce problem owners in your clinical, experimental, industrial or other partner networks
- BUILD: prepare your expertise and availability; apply for the selected challenges from 20 November

Choose the role that fits your contribution; proposing is not a bid to fund your own team.



What owners commit to

- One authorised contact, a clear problem and a data route
- A public-ready proposal and answers to relevant questions
- Both sandpit days: co-design, assessment input and feedback
- Data/domain support, agreed reviews and links to users

Sheffield: 21 January 2027, 11:00, to 22 January, 16:00.

UKOMAIN helps refine selected challenges and organises the sandpit.



Open benchmarks can use restricted data

Data: access and readiness

- Public, committed for release, or controlled / secure access.
- State permissions, conditions and expected availability.
- Bounded curation is welcome; avoid major collection or uncertain access.

Benchmark: open and reusable

- Open specifications, evaluation / baseline code and documentation.
- New reusable code must permit research and commercial reuse.
- Restricted data: public development resource + workable evaluation route.

The call does not prescribe one data licence. State third-party restrictions.
Participation and reuse must extend beyond the owner or its chosen suppliers.



Challenge proposal: four short answers

- Problem and beneficiaries | up to 150 words
- Why an open benchmark? | up to 150 words
- Data and evaluation route | up to 200 words
- What you bring and seek | up to 100 words

Public answers become the selected brief; private evidence stays separate.
A complete benchmark design or preformed delivery team is not required.



Joining the sandpit vs leading a project

Who can participate?

- UK-based; attend both Sheffield days and contribute afterwards.
- Researchers, engineers, specialists and experienced students.
- University employment is not required for every participant.

What each funded team needs

- One PI based at an eligible UK research institution.
- At least one PI / Co-I with relevant experience in open-source or benchmark development.
- Those ineligible for funding may contribute as unfunded partners.

Selection balances eligible investigators with complementary expertise.
A named PI or collaborator does not guarantee a sandpit place or funding.



What follows challenge selection?

- Publish the challenges; invite individual sandpit applications
- Participants form or develop teams around the challenges
- Owners and teams co-design and pitch benchmark projects
- Shortlisted teams submit final proposals and costings

Owners remain project partners. Funding is a separate competitive decision. Challenge or participant selection does not guarantee a project award.



R3 funding: build a usable benchmark

- £200,000 total; up to four funded projects
- Up to £50,000 per project (80% FEC)
- Up to five months - start by 1 April 2027
- Usable benchmark and test run by the agreed end date
- Potential R4 funding to support competition/adoption

Choose your next step

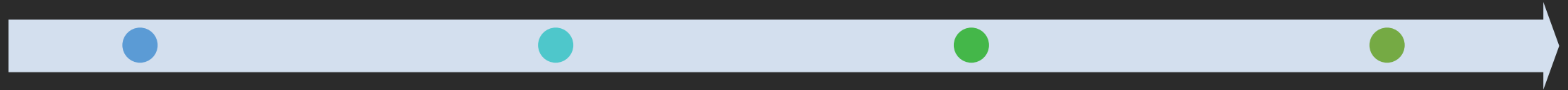


6 Nov · 16:00

Challenge
proposals close

11 Dec · 16:00

Sandpit
applications close



20 Nov

Challenges named
Sandpit applications
open

18 Dec

Participant
notifications

2026 dates. All deadlines are in UK local time.



Bring a problem worth benchmarking

Genuine need + usable data + committed owner

Challenge proposals: **6 November, 16:00 UK time**

forms.gle/zgMfoM68AiF7mvWz8

Sandpit applications open on 20 November

Full call, application forms, recording and FAQs

multimodalai.github.io/omaib-r3/

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Questions and discussion



Submit a challenge